Flexible operational structures and voluntary membership arrangements further bolster IO resilience. As the preceding chapter discussed, the MPIA, established by a coalition of WTO members, provides a compelling example. When Trump's refusal to confirm judges rendered the WTO's Appellate Body nonfunctional, the MPIA stepped in as a stopgap mechanism for resolving trade disputes, and appears to have played a helpful role (Pelc 2024). Similarly, the Paris Agreement's design allows for voluntary commitments, enabling countries to pursue ambitious climate policies even in the absence of populist-led states like the United States. This framework proved crucial when the United States exited the agreement in 2017, as the Paris Agreement continued to function, with other nations stepping up to fill the leadership void.

By embracing redundancy, fostering diverse partnerships, and embedding operational flexibility, IOs can preemptively safeguard their missions against populist resistance. These strategies not only ensure continuity but also position IOs as adaptive, forward-thinking institutions capable of thriving in a rapidly evolving global landscape.

RAISING BARRIERS TO EXIT

IOs and nonpopulist governments can also curtail the disruptive impacts of populist leaders by raising the barriers to exit, creating frameworks that discourage states from disengaging and making noncompliance a costly endeavor. Such measures not only deter withdrawal but also ensure that states contemplating exit face clear material consequences that isolate and penalize them for undermining collective commitments. Legislative bodies within member states play a pivotal role to this end by enacting domestic laws that complicate or delay the process of withdrawal. For instance, under the Biden administration, the United States sought to introduce a requirement for congressional approval before any future withdrawal from NATO.[6] This measure aimed to prevent unilateral exits by populist administrations.

Another effective way to reinforce states' commitments to IOs is to draw out the withdrawal process. The Paris Agreement offers a prime example, requiring a one-year waiting period after a country signals its intention to exit. This deliberate delay provides a crucial window for civil society,